

OH.3 Inspection Sequence

The inspections the Residential Code of Ohio actually names, the one that happens before any work at all, and what to record when nobody is required to inspect you.

Before you use this document

This is a process reference, not legal advice. Ohio writes one residential code for the whole state and applies it to your house by its own terms — and then, in that same code, excuses you from submitting plans, obtaining approvals, requesting inspections and getting a certificate of occupancy if no certified residential building department has jurisdiction over your parcel. What never depends on that is the code standard itself, the sewage treatment system permit, the private water system permit, and the contract and lien rules. Confirm every item with the office that will actually handle your parcel before you rely on it. The inspection list below is quoted from the Residential Code of Ohio's administration rule as filed with the Legislative Service Commission and read in September 2026.

OHIO NAMES ITS INSPECTIONS — AND HANDS YOU THE LIST

In most states the inspection schedule is whatever the local department prints on the back of the permit. Ohio writes the menu into the code and then requires the building official to give you your project's list at the moment your plans are approved.

OAC 4101:8-1-01, RCO section 108.2 — Required inspections

"At the time that the certificate of plan approval is issued, the residential building official shall provide to the owner, or the owner's representative, a list of all required inspections for each project. The required inspection list shall be created from the applicable inspections set forth in sections 108.2.1 to 108.2.12. The residential building official, upon notification from the owner or the owner's agent that the work is ready for inspection, shall cause the inspections set forth in the required inspection list to be made by an appropriately certified residential inspector in accordance with the approved residential construction documents."

Ask for that list in writing and keep it behind this sheet. It is the definitive answer to "what does this department actually want?", it is your right to receive it, and it removes every later argument about whether an inspection was required. If it does not arrive with your plan approval, ask again in writing.

And if the inspector does not come — RCO section 108.1

"It shall be the duty of the owner or the owner's authorized representative to cause the work to remain accessible and exposed for inspection purposes... until the work has been inspected to verify compliance with the approved construction documents, but **failure of the inspectors to inspect the work within four days, exclusive of Saturdays, Sundays, and legal holidays, after the work is ready for inspection, allows the work to proceed.** Subsequent work is allowed to proceed only to the point of the next required inspection."

This is one of the most useful sentences in the Ohio code for anyone on a schedule — and it comes with a condition you have to create yourself. The four days run from when the work is *ready* and the department has been *notified*. Put the request in writing, date it, photograph the exposed work the same day, and keep both. Without that record you cannot show when the clock started, and the protection is worth nothing.

THE FIRST ONE HAPPENS BEFORE YOU MOVE ANY DIRT

The first item on Ohio's list is not an inspection of construction. It is a survey requirement, it is easy to satisfy cheaply and almost impossible to satisfy late, and it catches people who have already excavated.

RCO section 108.2.1 — Lot line markers required

"Before any work is started in the construction of a residential building or an addition to a residential building to which the rules of the board are applicable under section 101.2, **all boundary lines shall be clearly marked at their intersections with permanent markers or with markers which are offset at a distance which is of record with the owner.**"

What that means in practice: get the corners pinned by a surveyor before the excavator arrives, not after the footing is poured and a neighbor asks a question. The rule accepts offset markers as long as the offset distance is on record with you — which is how surveyors normally protect pins from being destroyed by machinery. It costs a fraction of moving a foundation.

This is also the requirement that most often makes an owner-builder's site plan real rather than approximate. Your septic isolation distances are measured to the property line (OAC 3701-29-06(G)(3)(a)), your well keeps 10 feet from lot lines and easements (OAC 3701-28-07(J), Table 1), and your zoning setbacks are measured from the same lines. One survey serves all of it. If you are in a jurisdiction with no certified building department, RCO 108.2.1 does not bind you — but every one of those other distances still does, and they are all measured from boundaries you have to know.

THE INSPECTIONS, AS THE CODE DESCRIBES THEM

Read the trigger conditions carefully. Ohio writes them as "shall be made after...", which tells you exactly how far to get before you call — and in one case tells you that another inspection has to have passed first.

RCO sections 108.2.2 to 108.2.10

Inspection	When the code says it happens
108.2.2 Footing or foundation	"after excavations for footings are complete and any required reinforcing steel is in place. For concrete foundations, any required forms shall be in place prior to inspection. Materials for the foundation shall be on the job, except where concrete is ready mixed... the concrete need not be on the job"
108.2.3 Concrete slab and under-floor	"after in-slab and under-floor reinforcing steel and building service equipment, conduit, insulation, vapor retarder, piping accessories and other ancillary equipment items are in place, but before any concrete is placed or floor sheathing installed, including the subfloor "
108.2.4 Lowest floor elevation	The elevation certification required by section 322 is submitted to the building official. This is the floodplain one — it applies where section 322 does
108.2.5 Frame	"after the roof deck or sheathing, all framing, fire blocking and bracing are in place and pipes, chimneys and vents to be concealed are complete and the rough electrical, plumbing, heating wires, pipes and ducts are approved " — read that last clause twice; see the note below
108.2.6 Lath or gypsum board	"after lathing and gypsum board, interior and exterior, is in place, but before any plastering is applied or before gypsum board joints and fasteners are taped and finished." Exception: gypsum board that is not part of a fire-resistive assembly or a shear assembly
108.2.7 Fire-resistant penetrations	"Protection of joints and penetrations in fire-resistance-rated assemblies shall not be concealed from view until inspected and approved"
108.2.8 Energy efficiency	Compliance with Chapter 11, including "envelope insulation 'R' and 'U' values, fenestration 'U' value, duct system 'R' value, infiltration air barriers, caulking/sealing of openings in envelope and ductwork, and 'HVAC' and water heating equipment efficiency"
108.2.9 Building service equipment	Everything installed "in accordance with the approved construction documents, the equipment listings, and the manufacturer's installation instructions" — mechanical heating and ventilating, mechanical exhaust, plumbing, fire protection and electrical systems
108.2.10 Other inspections	The official may require others "to ascertain compliance", and on projects "of unusual magnitude" may require full-time project representation by a registered design professional or inspection agency

The sequencing mistake Ohio makes easy

In Ohio the rough trades clear before the frame does. RCO 108.2.5 does not say the framing inspection happens alongside the rough-ins or before them — it says the frame inspection is made after the framing is complete *and* "the rough electrical, plumbing, heating wires, pipes and ducts **are approved.**"

Most owner-builders schedule the other way round, because in plenty of jurisdictions elsewhere framing is inspected first and the trades follow. Booking it backwards here costs you a failed inspection and a re-inspection fee at the exact moment the drywall crew is standing in the driveway.

Plan the rough-in inspections as a cluster that ends with framing, and confirm with your department how it wants them called — some run them as one visit, some as four. Write the answer on the log at the end of this document.

What happens when an inspection passes is also written down, and it is worth knowing because it tells you where your evidence lives. Under RCO 108.2.11 the inspector "shall communicate the findings to the owner's on-site representative, shall make a note of the satisfactory inspection **on an on-site inspection record** and in the inspector's log, and communicate the findings to the residential building official", who then "shall issue the certificate of occupancy in accordance with section 111." **Keep that on-site inspection record.** It is the primary document a lender, insurer or buyer will ask for.

*Two more things the code allows. The building official "is authorized to accept reports of approved inspection agencies" (RCO 108.3), and the statute permits certified departments to take plan-examination and inspection reports from third-party examiners — but note who pays and what they cannot do: "Fees charged by a third-party examiner or inspector are in addition to any fees prescribed by the political subdivision... and are **the responsibility of the building owner**", and issuing the certificate of plan approval and the certificate of occupancy "**remains the exclusive authority** of the certified personnel" (§ 3781.10(E)(15)). A third party can inspect you. Only the department can sign you off.*

THE INSPECTIONS THAT HAPPEN WHEREVER YOU BUILD

These do not come from the building code and do not stop existing when no building department is certified for your parcel. On a rural build they may be the only inspections your house ever gets.

Record each of these as it happens

	Item	Date	Notes
☐	Sewage system — installation inspection by the board of health before covering. Nothing about this depends on a building department. Inspector _____ Date _____		

Record each of these as it happens

	Item	Date	Notes
☐	Sewage system — the twelve-month revisit. The board of health "shall inspect the completed system again not later than twelve months after the approval of the installation to observe the system's operation" (§ 3701-29-09(H)). Diarize it. Due _____ Done _____		
☐	Installer's as-built drawing received, showing any change in component locations and the distances to everything with an isolation requirement (§ 3701-29-09(F)). Date _____		
☐	Private water system — the pre-construction site review with the health district, then the final inspection and water sample. Sample result _____ Date _____		
☐	Plumbing. Enforcement runs on its own statutory track and may come from the health district, the Division of Industrial Compliance, a municipal building-inspection department or a contracting county department (§ 3781.03(C)). Establish which one, then book it. Office _____ Date _____		
☐	Building sewer / sanitary tap , if on public sewer — inspected by whoever issued it: city engineer, board of health or sewer purveyor. Office _____ Date _____		
☐	Driveway or culvert — the road authority's inspection of the approach. Office _____ Date _____		
☐	Electric service — your utility's own inspection or release before it energizes. In a jurisdiction with no electrical permit this is often the only outside look at your wiring, so ask early what it involves. Utility _____ Date _____		

WHEN NOBODY IS REQUIRED TO INSPECT YOU

If no building department certified for residential buildings has jurisdiction over your parcel, RCO 101.5 excuses you from requesting inspections and from obtaining a certificate of occupancy. **The code standard still applies to your house.** What disappears is the paperwork and the person who would have checked — which means the evidence has to come from you.

Build your own inspection record — it is an asset, not a chore

Photograph every stage before it is covered. Footings with steel in place. Under-slab plumbing and vapor retarder before the pour. Every wall cavity before insulation, from a distance and close up, with a tape measure in frame where a dimension matters. Roof deck and flashing. Panel interior with the dead front off. Date every photograph.

Hire the inspections you are not required to have. A private third-party inspector, an engineer for the foundation, or a licensed electrician to review your rough-in costs a fraction of one percent of the build. In a jurisdiction with no certified department there is nobody whose job it is to catch the mistake that burns the house down, and your own eye is the least reliable instrument on site.

Get a blower-door and duct test done anyway. They are cheap, they are the only objective measurement of whether the envelope you paid for exists, and the number is the single most persuasive thing you can hand an appraiser or a buyer later.

Write down who told you no permit was required, and when. An email from the county or the township, dated and filed behind OH.4, is the answer to the question a lender or title company will ask years from now. Without it, "there was no building department" is an assertion. With it, it is a record.

IF AN INSPECTION OR A REVIEW GOES AGAINST YOU

Ohio gives you three separate routes, and they run to three different places. Use them in order and in writing.

Three routes, three destinations

	Route	What it is for
1	The local board of building appeals	RCO section 110.1 provides for a hearing and a right of appeal from the residential building official's orders. This is the first stop for "the inspector is reading the code wrong"
2	The thirty-day silence rule	Plan approval is a "license", and failure to approve within thirty days is "an adjudication order denying the issuance of a license" requiring a hearing — and any denial "shall specify the reasons" (§ 3791.04(E)). A stalled review is a decision you can appeal, not a queue you must wait in

Three routes, three destinations

	Route	What it is for
3	The Board of Building Standards, for a conflicting local rule	A local authority may add residential regulations only if they do not conflict with the state code — and any person may ask the Board to rule on a conflict, which it must do within sixty days . If it finds a conflict and the rule is not necessary for health or safety, "the regulation is not valid and the local governing authority may not enforce" it (§ 3781.01(B) to (D))

One more worth knowing if you are in an unincorporated area of a county that runs a building department: R.C. § 307.37 builds a drainage review into the county building permit application and puts a clock on it — "If the review is not completed within the thirty-day period..., the proposed new construction **shall be deemed to have no adverse effects on existing surface or subsurface drainage**." That section was amended effective 9 April 2025, so confirm the current text before relying on the detail.

INSPECTION LOG — RECORD EVERY ONE

Every inspection, whether or not anybody required it

	Item	Date	Notes
☐	Lot lines marked — surveyor and date, BEFORE any work Surveyor _____ Date _____		
☐	Footing / foundation Result _____ Inspector _____		
☐	Concrete slab / under-floor, before the pour Result _____ Inspector _____		
☐	Lowest floor elevation certificate, if in a flood hazard area Result _____ Date _____		
☐	Rough plumbing Result _____ Inspector _____		
☐	Rough electrical Result _____ Inspector _____		
☐	Rough heating — wires, pipes and ducts Result _____ Inspector _____		
☐	Frame — only after the three rough-ins above are approved Result _____ Inspector _____		

Every inspection, whether or not anybody required it

	Item	Date	Notes
☐	Lath or gypsum board, before taping Result _____ Inspector _____		
☐	Fire-resistant penetrations, before concealment Result _____ Inspector _____		
☐	Insulation and energy — envelope, fenestration, ducts, sealing Result _____ Inspector _____		
☐	Blower door / duct leakage test result Result _____ Date _____		
☐	Building service equipment — mechanical, plumbing, electrical Result _____ Inspector _____		
☐	Sewage system installation, before covering Result _____ Inspector _____		
☐	Private water system final and water sample Result _____ Date _____		
☐	Electric service release Utility _____ Date _____		
☐	Certificate of occupancy, if one is issued here No. _____ Date _____		
☐	Sewage system twelve-month revisit Result _____ Date _____		

Whether or not a building department ever looked at this house, the log above is the record that it was built to a standard. Keep the on-site inspection record, the health district's approvals, the as-built septic drawing, the water sample, the blower-door number and the photographs together with this sheet. Three years from now, when an appraiser, an insurer or a buyer asks what your house was built to, this folder is the entire answer — and in a jurisdiction with no certified residential building department, it is the only answer that exists.